A Bone Close to My Brain

By Dan Dietz

A MAN stands beside an easel; he uncaps a marker and draws a big tooth on the paper.

MAN: **(Pg 16-23)** today my brother is a dentist

he knows all about these little bones

huddling tight inside your mouth

incisors, bicuspids, wisdoms way in the back

he knows them all

their shapes and contours

their uses and misuses

the damage they can reasonably take

from impact or decay

my brother is a dentist today

i don't mean he just got certified

i don't mean he opened a practice

i mean that today my brother is a dentist

just like yesterday he was a radiologist

and last month he was a reporter for the *new york times*

only two things about him stay the same

day in, day out

his address, this tidy little house in new jersey

which we've shared for the nine years

since our parents passed away

and the fact that i am his big brother

no matter what else he erases and remakes

inside his mind

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these two facts sit solid and bonehard

within his head

INTRODUCTION

What are the limits of brotherly love? And what do they have to do with the 32 bones huddling tight inside your mouth? Through sparse dialogue and childlike illustrations, a man describes his relationship with his younger brother -- who is both brilliant and mentally ill -- and the heartbreaking decision he has to make.

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MAN: he can't feed himself

he doesn't grasp the need to fuel his body

he can't bathe himself

left on his own, he'll either starve or stink himself to death

he doesn't live in his skin, his stomach, his fingernails

he lives here

in the bulbous gray organ

just above and behind

the roof of his mouth

that's his house

(MAN draws a roof and windows on the tooth, maybe even a chimney with smoke)

the rest of him

skin, stomach, fingernails

is like a yard *(draws a yard by the house)*

a yard that needs a full-time, round the dock landscaper

to keep from going to hell

that's me

i tend him

he trusts me

anyone else comes near the yard

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(skin, stomach, fingernails)
he screams, hits, bites
gets arrested, gets bailed out, forgets, etc.
but not me
he would never hurt me

except for today
today he will hurt me
in about ten minutes
he will walk in here
lay me down on this chair
and tear out of my head
a single, white, completely healthy
tooth *(flips to a new sheet, draws a new tooth)*
and i will let him

i can't get used to the way teeth look
strange
spiny
like they belong on the outside
of some prehistoric fish
not sprouting from my face
maybe i should smile more
but i was always that way
even as a kid
i can't find one picture of me
smiling showing my teeth
always just a twist of the lips
to indicate a grin

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gerald always smiled with teeth
he's smiling right now
in the kitchen, sterilizing his instruments
which consist of a penlight
and a pair of pliers

he's brilliant
he learns this stuff in just hours
pores over textbooks
random ones i pick up
from the public library
to keep his house *(draws a roof on the tooth, draws a yard)*
occupied *(draws a happy stick figure waving from the house)*

he dives into the volumes
(the only medication he'll accept)
and the next time i see him
he's completely reborn
he's memorized it all
he's a dentist
(radiologist, reporter)
and he can't remember a day
when he wasn't a dentist
(radiologist, reporter)

he was reading tolstoy at age eight
studying fractals at eleven
those huge numbers
blooming out infinite all over the place

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numbers that want to be pictures
he called them

what does a number do
if it wants to be a picture

he grew into adolescence
his head devouring everything
like his eyes were mouths
awards, acclaim
the "g" word tossed about
(and i don't mean "gerald")
by people important enough to believe
he was slated to graduate high school
before his sixteenth birthday

then mom and dad died
when our house
got broken into *(draws a hole on the house and an arrow pointing into the hole)*
attempted robbery
became
attempted rape
became

i was away at college
i didn't have to come downstairs
didn't have to try to stop it
try to save
but gerald

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he was fifteen
the same age as the boy
they caught and convicted
after finding his skin cells
beneath my mother's

i moved back home
took a break from school
gerald however refused to take a break
so close to graduation
less than a year
but the things he started saying
and doing

it was like his mind had twisted
to indicate a person *(points to the person waving from the house)*
a person
that wants to be a picture
and he'll erase and try again
until he gets the picture
right

he's beautiful at night
he sits in his room
soft light
pages blurring by

he was expelled
for tearing open a substitute's blouse
he insisted she was in danger

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her beat was irregular
he could hear it across the room
he had to press his stethoscope
to her bare chest to be sure

silly
tragic moments are always
so f***ing silly

like this one
today
(flips to a new sheet, draws a new tooth)
today my little brother
will remove my tooth
which he is convinced
upon examination with his penlight
is rife with decay
(draws holes on the tooth)
little holes
in a bone close to my brain

he will administer anesthetic
a rag steeped in ether
(which he got from god knows where)
and pluck out my tooth
("pluck" is probably not
the right word)
and smile
believing

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he has saved me from danger

i will give him this belief

today

and tomorrow

i will take him to a place

where they will administer

a more sophisticated anesthetic

one which will

maybe

combined with other treatments

over the course of years

help

tomorrow

i will turn him over to people

who will break into his house

(draws a roof on the tooth, a yard, arrows pointing into the holes in the tooth)

and do their best

as he flails and screams

to clean the damn thing up

i will leave him there

i will erase him and

because i can't i

you wake up one day

and the decay

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i can't find myself
in this picture

i will leave him there
and return here *(turns to a fresh blank page)*
to my house
and gerald
i know
will hold onto my tooth
forever
a bone close to my brain
perhaps it will reside
beneath his pillow
as he sleeps
giving him dreams
of his big brother
crying "don't hate me"

don't hate me

and perhaps
somewhere in the back of my mouth
i will feel the head
of my little brother shift
in the night
every night
after
tonight.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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